

can jazz fusion saxophonist George Brookes and Indian ghatam maestro Vikku Vinayakram, a founding member of fusion giants Shakti. 'Iss Tan Dhan', which features the latter, is an inventive, atmospheric trippy track featuring poetry by Kabir as well as Tamil lyrics contributed by Vinayakram himself.

"You know, he's the one who expressed interest," says Joshi of the collaboration with Vinayakram. "Nikhil, Amit [Kilam] and Rahul [Ram] had gone to his concert and he said 'You've collaborated with my son, when will you collaborate with me?' It's the God of Rhythm asking, how can you say no?"

Here, as well as on the prog rock-leaning two-parter title tracks, Indian Ocean continues to iterate its trademark sound as the band pushes into new directions following the departure of founding member Susmit Sen in 2013. Older fans might miss Sen's signature guitar, but Rao's fresh approach adds a new dimension to the band's sound, particularly on upbeat, Carnatic-inspired instrumental 'Rebirth'. What remains consistent is the band's love for long songs that transform as they go. Even in an increasingly algorithm-driven, low-attention-span market, Indian Ocean insists on giving songs the time and space to evolve as they will.

"We know that music consumption has changed, attention spans have declined, so we did have some healthy discussions with our management about how to present our music in today's rapidly changing world," says Rao. "We did think about radio edits, but we decided against it. As Rahul [Ram] told us, we should just continue doing what we are good at."

The band is now touring behind the record, with shows scheduled for every weekend of May and more legs to be added soon. Thirty-four years as a touring band can add up to a lot of wear and tear—both physical and emotional—and I wonder if especially the older members of the group sometimes feel the strain. Both acknowledge that it can be tiring, but at the end of the day, they're just grateful to be able to do what they do.

"After Covid, I'm never going to complain about being overworked," jokes Rao. "Yes, waking up at 4 am in a hotel to go to the airport night after night isn't the most glamorous part of being a musician. But we are very grateful to be doing what we do."

In between shows, the band is also working on a couple of film tracks, following on their successes with movies like *Masaan* (2015) and *Peepli [Live]* (2010). They're also thinking of the next album, which they assure us won't take another nine years, though Joshi is quick to point out that they had done a bunch of other stuff, including at least two film soundtracks in that time.

"Those [compositions] have restrictions, in terms of time, thought process, someone else's dictum," he says. "So, when we have a free hand to create something of our own, we like to give it the time to evolve, till it's something we're proud of. That process is long because we enjoy doing it that way." ■

Bhanuj Kappal

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albums—including 2002's *Insane Biography*—under their belt, and released their latest EP *111* last year. There's also a bit of controversy, with the band involved in a legal tussle with former vocalist Baiju Dharmajan, but they continue to play and tour.

▼ PARIKRAMA

Formed in 1991, Parikrama were a dominant force in Indian rock in the 1990s, enjoying success with 1995 single 'Till I'm No One Again' and 2001's 'But It Rained'. Eventually overshadowed by more prolific newcomers, Parikrama has continued to tour relentlessly, even after the tragic death of guitarist Sonam Sherpa in 2020.





▲ THERMAL AND A QUARTER

This Bengaluru quartet have been putting out contrarian, groove-laden rock music since 1996, and their 2005 release *Plan B* is an Indian rock classic. They continue to tour and make music (their latest release being last year's 'What World'), while also running their own music school Taaqademy.

by Bhanuj Kappal